

THE FORMATIVE WOUND

Lesson 3 · Resource 1 of 3

You've found what your character does. In Lesson 2, you found what they believe. Neither of those explains itself. Somewhere behind the belief is the specific thing that taught it — and until you find that, the belief is only decoration on a person you haven't fully built yet.

That's what this resource is about: not the technique for finding it — that's Resource 2 — but what you're actually looking for when you go looking.

What a Formative Wound Actually Is

A formative wound is the experience — or the sustained absence of one — that taught your character a fact about reality. Not an opinion they hold. A fact, as far as they're concerned. The way gravity is a fact. Nobody argues with gravity, and your character has never once argued with this.

It produced a conclusion, and the conclusion hardened into something your character now treats as simply how things are: *worth equals usefulness. No one protects you unless you protect yourself first. Love is conditional on performance.* The specific sentence changes character to character. What doesn't change is the shape — a belief that was installed, once, by something real, and never revisited since.

That's the distinction worth sitting with. The wound isn't the trauma industry's version of a wound — the single dramatic event a support group might name. It's smaller and more exact than that. It's the specific moment, or the specific pattern repeated long enough, that this particular character couldn't have drawn any other conclusion from.

Why It Has to Be Specific

Psychologist Ronnie Janoff-Bulman's research on what she called our "assumptive world" found that people carry a small set of core assumptions — the world is benevolent, the world is meaningful, I am worthy — and that these assumptions are typically formed (or shattered) not by abstract reasoning but by specific, concrete experience. Nobody reasons their way into believing the world is safe or unsafe. Something happens, or fails to happen, and the belief simply arrives, already finished.

That's the mechanism behind the hidden truth you found in Lesson 2. Aaron Beck's work on core beliefs — the same research underneath that lesson — describes these beliefs as absolute and global specifically because they were never argued into place. They were experienced into place. Which means the wound isn't the emotional color behind the belief. It's the evidence. The actual scene the belief is standing on.

That's why "a difficult childhood" or "a history of abandonment" won't hold up as a wound, even though both are true and both are common. They're categories, not evidence. A category could have happened to anyone and produced any number of different beliefs. The wound you're looking for is small enough, particular enough, that it could only have produced this belief in this character.

What It Isn't

It isn't a theme. Abandonment, failure, and loss are names for categories of wound, not the wound itself. If you can put a one-word label on it, you're not there yet.

It isn't an emotion. "She felt invisible" describes the result, not the cause. A camera couldn't film a feeling. It could film the scene that produced it.

It doesn't have to be catastrophic. The most specific wounds are often the quietest ones — a single sentence overheard once, a pattern sustained for years without a single dramatic moment inside it. Drama isn't the requirement. Precision is.

The Test

Here's the question that confirms you've found it, not just something plausible: *does the connection between the wound and the belief require an argument, or is it immediate?*

If you have to explain why this experience would produce this belief — walk someone through the logic, build the case — you're still one layer above the real thing. The actual wound doesn't need defending. You show it, and the belief is obvious. Nobody has to be talked into seeing it.

That's the standard the next resource is built around.

Next: Resource 2, The Diagnostician's Method — the three-stage process for finding the wound rather than reasoning your way to a plausible one.